Bill Approval Inbox

An AI-native wedge into Accounts Payable for Volopay

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Volopay owns how companies **spend** on cards. The adjacent, stickier wound is how they **pay vendors** — Accounts Payable. This is a plan to enter AP through the cheapest possible wedge: let finance teams capture and approve vendor bills by simply talking to Claude, with Volopay as the system of record.

1 THE OPPORTUNITY: AP IS VOLOPAY'S NATURAL NEXT MARKET

Cards govern discretionary spend; **AP is where the largest, most predictable money actually leaves the business** — rent, cloud, contractors, SaaS. Yet most finance teams still capture bills by hand, chase approvals across email and Slack, and miss due dates. Volopay already sits on the spend graph and the payment rails, so AP is an expansion, not a new company.

The entry point is **capture** — the top of the AP funnel. Own the moment a bill is logged and approved, and you earn the right to own the payment that follows, plus the float, FX, and spend data around it.

2 THE INSIGHT: MEET FINANCE INSIDE THE AI THEY ALREADY USE

Turning "*AWS, $1,200, due Nov 30*" into a structured, approvable bill is exactly what an LLM does well and what humans find tedious. Every finance team now works beside an AI assistant. So instead of asking them to log into yet another dashboard, **meet them where they already are** — inside Claude, over the Model Context Protocol (MCP). A bill mentioned in chat becomes a tracked, approvable item in Volopay, with zero new software to learn.

3 WHY IT'S DEFENSIBLE (THE "WHY NOT JUST CLAUDE?" ANSWER)

Claude can draft, but it cannot be the **system of record for money**. It does not persist data, enforce approval policy, or hold an audit trail. This product deliberately puts AI where it is strong — capture and reasoning — and keeps the money-record where it must stay: inside Volopay, human-approved.

> **The boundary is the moat.** The app never calls an LLM; Claude never holds the data. That single design choice is both the defensibility and the compliance story a finance buyer needs to say yes.

4 THE GROWTH ENGINE

Low-CAC distribution. MCP is a new channel. A finance lead adds the connector once; every teammate's Claude can now file bills into Volopay. Land inside the AI tool, expand into the platform.

One-sentence activation. Time-to-value is a single message — no onboarding, no training. That lifts trial activation and hands sales a 30-second "wow" in any demo.

The wedge **compounds**: capture → approval → payment → spend data. Each step raises switching cost and pulls the customer deeper into Volopay.

> **The business case in one line:** Own the moment a bill is mentioned, and you are positioned to own the payment. AP is Volopay's natural next market, and AI-native capture is the cheapest way in.

Market	AP expansion off the existing spend graph
Wedge	AI-native bill capture via MCP
Moat	AI on top, system-of-record underneath

5 WHAT I BUILT — ONE FLOW, DONE WELL

A **live** web app plus an MCP server Claude connects to as a custom connector. In Claude, a finance user says "*Add a bill: AWS, $1,200, due Nov 30*". Claude calls create_bill; the bill lands in Volopay's **Pending Approval** queue; a human reviews, edits, approves, marks paid, or rejects it; everything persists and stays live on the internet. Three tools, nothing more:

MCP TOOL	WHAT IT DOES
create_bill	Add a vendor bill (starts as *pending*), tagged as captured via Claude.
list_bills	List bills, optionally filtered by status.
update_bill	Approve, mark paid, reject, or edit a bill's fields.

6 THE DESIGN PRINCIPLE: AI ON TOP, RECORD UNDERNEATH

A deliberate split of responsibilities is what makes this shippable in a money workflow:

RESPONSIBILITY	APP (VOLOPAY)	CLAUDE (AI)
Understand plain language & extract fields	—	✓
Decide which action to take	—	✓
Store data durably & keep the audit trail	✓	—
Approval workflow & statuses	✓	—
Final human approval of money decisions	✓	—

No LLM runs inside the app — there are no AI keys in the codebase. Claude never holds the data. **That boundary is the entire safety and compliance argument.**

7 WHY ONE FLOW, NOT TEN

I scoped this to capture → approval on purpose. A **flawless narrow flow** proves both the pattern and the safety boundary; breadth would have diluted both and produced a fragile demo. The restraint is the point — it shows where AI belongs in finance, and where it does not.

8 HOW WE'D MEASURE IT

Activation: % of connected teams filing ≥1 bill in week 1.

Capture rate: bills created via Claude vs. manual entry.

Cycle time: mention → approved.

Expansion: % of capture teams that enable payment.

Trust: % of AI-created bills edited before approval (lower = higher trust).

9 ROADMAP

Near: OAuth on the connector + SSO; approval policy (spend limits, approver routing, duplicate detection).

Mid: invoice-PDF ingestion (Claude reads the attachment, human approves); accounting/ledger sync; Slack approver nudges.

Long: full AP suite — capture → approve → pay — as a Volopay product line.

10 HONEST LIMITATIONS

Demo-stage, by design: the MCP endpoint and UI are unauthenticated; the free host cold-starts (~30–60s) after idle; there is no policy engine, invoice attachment, or multi-tenant separation yet. Each is a known, scoped next step — not a surprise.

Live app: volopay-bill-inbox.onrender.com **MCP:** /mcp/ **Code:** github.com/rwagh831-pm/volopay-bill-inbox